

A 7.92m jump early in the 2025 season qualified him for his first NCAA indoor championships. Later, he jumped a personal best of 8.14m at the Michael Johnson Invitational, which qualified him for the NCAA outdoor final, where he finished fifth. It was the high point of a solid, if not spectacular, comeback season.

At the start of 2026, however, Carter sensed that Lokesh was building towards something much more significant. "Early in the season, Lokesh competed in Oklahoma at the JD Martin Invitational. He won with 7.85m, but he also had a foul jump by a very narrow margin that I estimated was at least 8.20m. That gave him confidence that he had a really big jump in him," says Carter. That would come at the biggest stage possible — at the NCAA Indoor Championships final.

Before the competition, Lokesh wasn't thinking about his competitors. "I just thanked God that I had another opportunity to compete at this level," he says.

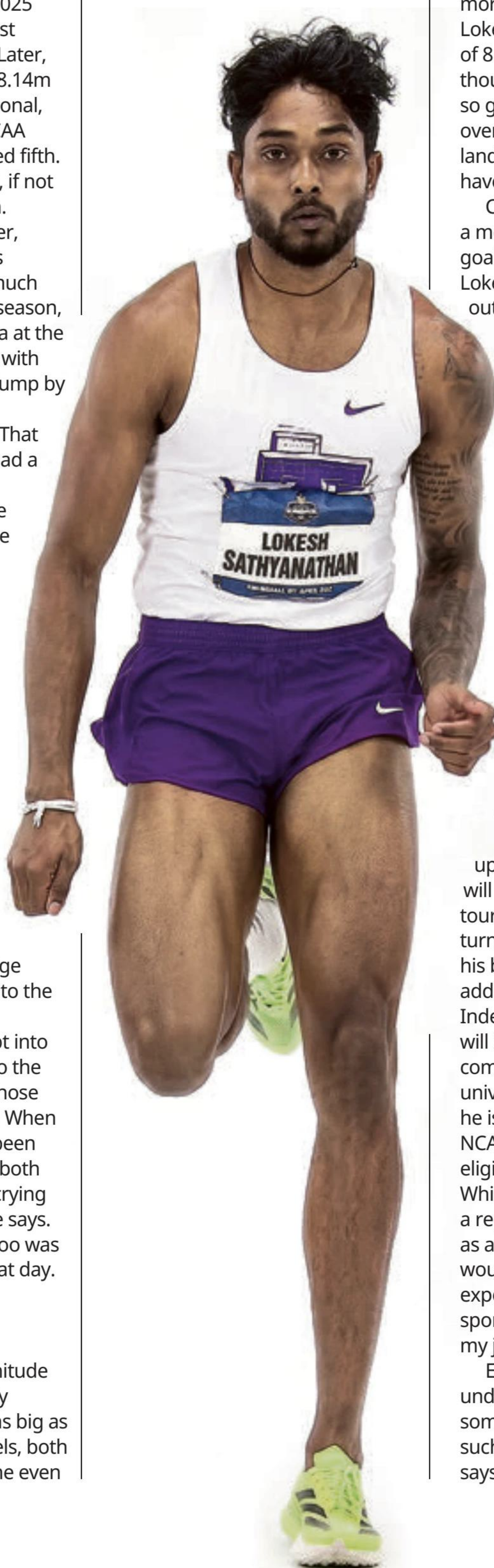
In second place after three attempts, everything came together in his fourth jump. Running in hard, he hit the board square. Using the double hitch kick, he cycled his legs twice as he took off before landing near the far edge of the pit. The jump put him into the lead, which he never gave up.

When it ended, Lokesh leapt into his coach's arms. He pointed to the sky in tribute to his mother, whose picture he carries everywhere. When he called his father, who had been following updates from India, both were in tears. "We were both crying but they were happy tears," he says.

Coach Carter admitted he too was crying when he went home that day. "It was just a really emotional moment," he says.

Bigger goals

However, despite the magnitude of the win, neither has formally celebrated it. That's because, as big as becoming NCAA champion feels, both believe Lokesh could have done even



more. In his final attempt of the day, Lokesh had made another huge jump of 8.17m. When he came off the sand though he grimaced. "Everything was so good in the take-off that I got overexcited and dropped my hips on landing. It cost me 20–30 cm. It could have been 8.40m," he says.

Carter hopes that the miss acts as a motivation. "Both of us have bigger goals that we want to accomplish. Lokesh's goal is to jump over 8.50m outdoors," he says.

With the Indian record currently standing at 8.42m (Jeswin Aldrin), that won't be easy, but Carter is optimistic. "It's very possible. He has the ability to be one of the best Indian jumpers of all time. Right now, our challenge is to stay consistent with technique. I know he has the technical ability to get to the 8.50m mark. It's just about the little things — eating right and competing in the right events," he says. There are also Lokesh's own ambitions. "I want to compete on the biggest stages and win a major medal for India at the Commonwealth and Asian Games," he says.

This, though, won't be entirely up to him. To represent India, he will have to take part in selection tournaments in the country. That, in turn, means frequent travel between his base at Tarleton and India — adding up to a significant expense. Indeed, even competing in the USA will be challenging in the months to come. Having already competed in university-level competitions in India, he is no longer eligible for outdoor NCAA events and has only one year of eligibility left for indoor competitions. While he can still take part in them as a representative of Tarleton, it will be as an unattached athlete, meaning he would have to cover his own expenses. "So far, I don't have a sponsor. If I get one, it would make my journey much easier," he says.

Even so, Lokesh remains undeterred. "I think I'm meant to do something special. I've already come such a long way. I'll keep pushing," he says.